



Kate Kucherova

CMA Candidate | Finance & FP&A | Portfolio Project 2026

Accounting Analyst · Financial Analyst · Operations Finance

Claire Studio — FP&A & Small Business Finance Case Study

About the Business

Claire — Studio of Physical & Aesthetic Development was a children's fitness, dance, and martial arts studio in Bataysk, Rostov Oblast, Russia. The studio offered choreography, fitness, karate, and gymnastics across up to two rented halls, serving a peak of 53 students across five programs at its height in Spring 2021.

I co-founded the studio in November 2019 and held full ownership of its financial operations — serving as financial manager and payroll administrator throughout, along with day-to-day duties beyond finance to keep the studio lean. The studio operated from November 2019 through July 2022, at which point I emigrated to the United States and transferred the business to my co-founder.

Data Source & What Was Built

This project began with 847 real cash transactions from the studio's operating records — a messy mix of revenue, expenses, owner draws, capital contributions, and inventory purchases recorded in raw ledger format. I cleaned, classified, and restructured this data into a formula-driven FP&A model built entirely in Excel.

The model follows a professional data flow: *Structured source data → Monthly P&L → Annual KPIs → Budget vs Actual → Management Financials → Unit Economics & Break-Even*

Key Financial Results

Total Revenue (Nov 2019 – Jul 2022)	\$275,336
Peak Year Revenue (2021)	\$120,892
All-Period Net Operating Income	\$84,990
All-Period NOI Margin	30.9%
Cumulative Cash After Owner Draws	\$35,018
Best Month (Mar 2022)	\$14,926
2021 Budget Achievement	Favorable — Revenue +2.7%, NOI + \$2,418
Second Hall Expansion Break-Even	Reached by late-2021 run-rate

Key Business Insights

1. Rent was the dominant fixed cost — and the expansion made it bigger.

Rent accounted for \$110,230 of total operating costs across all periods — the single largest expense category, exceeding payroll by nearly 3x. When the second hall was leased in early 2021, monthly rent increased from \$2,800 to \$4,675 — a 67% step-up in the largest fixed cost. The break-even analysis shows this expansion was not fully covered by direct expansion revenue until late 2021, but the total business revenue grew enough to absorb the higher cost base.

2. Choreography was the studio's core revenue driver throughout its life.

Choreography generated \$141,000 across the full period — just over half of total revenue — and remained the largest single program even as karate launched in 2020 and hall rental income grew from 2021 onward. That concentration made pricing decisions on this one program, including a 25% price increase in September 2021, disproportionately important to the studio's overall trajectory.

3. COVID created a clean before/after view of the business.

April and May 2020 were excluded from the model due to full closure during COVID lockdowns. The reopening in June 2020 effectively resets the business — and the contrast is sharp. Pre-COVID revenue averaged around \$4,050/month (Nov 2019–Mar 2020); post-reopening the studio rebuilt quickly, reaching \$10,837 in September 2020. By 2022 the run-rate exceeded \$13,000/month before the wind-down began.

4. The 2021 budget was favorable across nearly every line.

Actual 2021 revenue exceeded budget by \$3,192 (2.7%), driven by strong choreography and karate enrollment. Expenses came in only \$774 over budget despite adding a second hall — because advertising spend was \$489 below plan and class supply costs were \$297 below plan. NOI beat budget by \$2,418. The one unfavorable revenue line was fitness, which recovered more slowly than planned.

Finance & Accounting Skills Demonstrated

Data Cleaning & Classification	Transformed 847 raw cash transactions into a structured, auditable model with consistent revenue and expense categories.
Revenue Analysis	Built monthly P&L by program (choreography, fitness, karate) showing enrollment trends, price changes, and seasonal patterns.
Budgeting & Variance Analysis	Constructed a 2021 management operating budget from run-rate assumptions; produced monthly and annual budget vs actual with F/U flags and written commentary.
Unit Economics	Modeled cost per class, revenue per student, and contribution margin by program using April 2021 peak-month data.
Expansion Decision Analysis	Built a break-even model for the second hall leasing decision; quantified incremental fixed cost and analyzed revenue coverage over time.
Management Financials	Produced income statement, cash flow summary, and financial position snapshot following U.S. GAAP conventions adapted for a small service business.
Accounting Treatment	Applied correct classification across revenue recognition, COGS, depreciation, owner distributions, deferred revenue, and journal entries.
Excel Financial Modeling	Built 16-tab formula-driven workbook: data flows from structured source tab through monthly P&L to all downstream analysis.

Kate Kucherova | CMA Candidate | katekucherova.nc@gmail.com
Business Facebook page: [Claire Studio](#) | Portfolio 2026